

Herod the Great: A Cruel Jewish Ruler of Judea

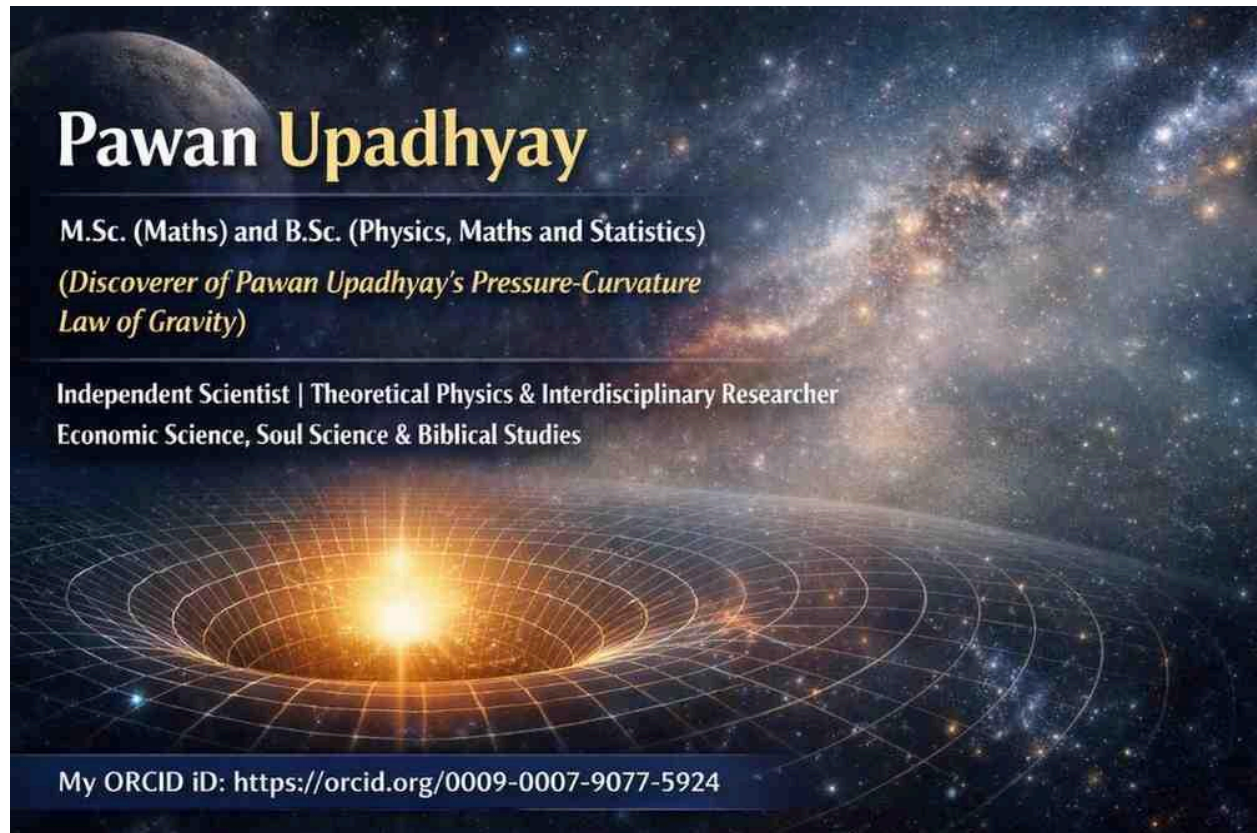
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Herod the Great (c. 73–4 BCE) was the Roman-appointed king of Judea. He came from an **Idumean family that had converted to Judaism**, and his family had become part of the Jewish political establishment. Herod therefore ruled a predominantly Jewish population while presenting himself as a legitimate ruler of Judea.

Herod's reign was characterized by a striking contradiction. He was one of the greatest builders of the ancient Jewish world, most famously transforming and greatly enlarging the **Second Temple in Jerusalem**, yet he was also notorious for ruthless political violence.

1. Herod killed members of the Jewish royal family

Herod married **Mariamne I**, a Hasmonean princess, partly to strengthen his claim to the Jewish throne. Nevertheless, he eventually had Mariamne executed. He also eliminated several members of the Hasmonean dynasty because he regarded them as potential rivals.

2. Herod executed his own sons

Herod's suspicion extended even to his own family. He ordered the execution of his sons **Alexander and Aristobulus** in 7 BCE after accusing them of conspiring against him. Shortly before Herod's death, his son **Antipater** was also executed on Herod's orders.

The killing of his own children illustrates the extreme nature of Herod's political paranoia.

3. He brutally suppressed opposition

Herod maintained his kingdom through military power and a system of political surveillance. Individuals and groups suspected of threatening his authority could face imprisonment, confiscation of property, or execution.

4. His relationship with his Jewish subjects was complicated

Herod could not simply be described as an enemy of Judaism. He sponsored enormous Jewish religious and architectural projects. His rebuilding of the Jerusalem Temple became one of the greatest construction achievements of ancient Judea.

At the same time, many Jews distrusted him because:

- his family was **Idumean rather than descended from the traditional Judean royal dynasty**;
- his throne depended heavily upon **Roman political and military support**;
- he executed members of the Hasmonean priestly and royal family;
- he employed extensive political repression.

Thus, **Herod could simultaneously promote Jewish religious institutions and brutally oppress Jewish people who threatened his political authority.**

5. Herod and the birth of Jesus

This historical background makes the account in **Matthew 2** particularly significant. Matthew presents Herod as becoming alarmed when the Magi ask about the newborn “**king of the Jews.**” Herod responds by attempting to eliminate the perceived rival.

Matthew subsequently describes Herod ordering the killing of male children in and around Bethlehem. This particular episode should be distinguished from Herod's numerous executions that are independently described by **Josephus**; the Bethlehem massacre is reported in Matthew but is not independently recorded by Josephus.

Conclusion

Herod the Great was therefore a **Jewish/Judaized Idumean king ruling Judea under Roman authority**, and his reign provides a striking example of how political power could coexist with religious patronage. He expanded the Temple and sponsored Jewish institutions while also executing relatives, political opponents, and members of the Jewish royal and priestly elite.

The historical picture is not simply “**Herod hated the Jews.**” Rather, it is that **Herod was a ruler of Judea who could be a major patron of Jewish religion and culture while simultaneously using extraordinary cruelty against Jews whom he perceived as threats to his throne.**

Idumean Jews and Hasmonean Jews: A Historical Note

1. Who were the Idumeans?

The **Idumeans** (Hebrew: *Edom*) were the descendants of the ancient **Edomites**, a people traditionally associated with the region south of Judea, roughly corresponding to parts of southern Judea and the northern Negev.

The Edomites were distinct from the Israelites in origin and had a long history of conflict and interaction with the Jewish people. In the biblical tradition, Edom was associated with **Esau**, while Israel was associated with Jacob.

By the Hellenistic period, however, the political and demographic situation had changed considerably. Idumeans increasingly came under Jewish political control.

2. The Hasmonean conquest of Idumea

A crucial turning point occurred under **John Hyrcanus I**, a Hasmonean ruler, in the late second century BCE.

According to the Jewish historian **Josephus**, Hyrcanus conquered the Idumeans and required them to accept circumcision and adopt Jewish law if they wished to remain in their territory.

This is the historical basis for describing the Idumeans as having undergone **forced or coercive conversion to Judaism**.

The process is important because it meant that, by Herod's time, Idumeans could be regarded as Jews religiously and politically even though their ancestral origin was different from that of the older Judean population.

3. Who were the Hasmoneans?

The **Hasmoneans** were a Jewish ruling dynasty that emerged from the **Maccabean revolt** against the Seleucid Empire in the second century BCE.

The dynasty began with **Mattathias and his sons**, particularly **Judas Maccabeus** and his successors.

The Hasmoneans eventually established an independent Jewish state in Judea, ruling from approximately **140 BCE until Herod's rise to power in 37 BCE**.

They combined several forms of authority:

- political kingship;
- military power;
- control over Judean territory;
- and, in some cases, the Jewish high priesthood.

This produced considerable political and religious controversy because some Jews questioned whether the Hasmoneans had the proper qualifications to combine **kingly and priestly authority**.

4. Idumean Jews versus Hasmonean Jews

It is important not to imagine these as two completely separate religions. **Both groups could be Jewish in religious identity**, especially by the first century BCE.

The major distinction was primarily **ancestry, historical origin, and political background**.

	Idumean Jews	Hasmonean/Judean Jews
Ancestral origin	Edomite/Idumean	Judean/Israelite Jewish population
Original territory	Idumea, south of Judea	Judea and surrounding regions
Relationship to Judaism	Incorporated into Judaism under Hasmonean rule	Established Jewish population

Major historical turning point	Conquest and Judaization under John Hyrcanus I	Maccabean revolt and Hasmonean state
Political importance	Increasingly integrated into Judean society	Ruling dynasty of independent Judea
Famous later figure	Herod the Great	Mariamne I and the Hasmonean royal family

5. Herod's Idumean background

This distinction becomes particularly important with **Herod the Great**.

Herod's father, **Antipater**, was an Idumean. Herod therefore came from a family whose ancestral background was Edomite/Idumean but whose community had been incorporated into Judaism generations earlier.

Herod was consequently not simply an outsider who suddenly conquered a Jewish kingdom. He emerged from a **Judaized Idumean family that had become deeply involved in Judean politics**.

His father Antipater became an influential political figure, and Herod eventually obtained Roman support and became king of Judea in **37 BCE**.

6. Why did Herod have a legitimacy problem?

Herod's Idumean ancestry contributed to questions about his legitimacy.

The Hasmoneans had established themselves as the ruling Jewish dynasty after the Maccabean revolt. Herod, by contrast, was from a **Judaized Idumean family** and was not a member of the Hasmonean dynasty.

This became particularly significant because Herod married **Mariamne I**, a Hasmonean princess.

The marriage had an obvious political purpose: it connected Herod to the old Jewish royal dynasty.

But Herod remained deeply suspicious of the Hasmoneans.

Ironically, the very family connection that strengthened his legitimacy also created a potential political threat.

7. Herod's destruction of the Hasmonean family

Herod eventually eliminated much of the Hasmonean family.

Among those executed were important members of the dynasty, including **Aristobulus III**, **Mariamne I**, and her sons **Alexander and Aristobulus**.

This was not simply ethnic conflict between “Idumeans” and “Jews.” It was fundamentally a **struggle over political legitimacy and royal power within the Jewish state**.

Herod himself was Jewish by the religious identity of his family and kingdom, but his **Idumean ancestry distinguished him from the older Hasmonean ruling house**.

8. An important historical caution

It would be misleading to say:

“Idumeans were not Jews.”

That is too simplistic for the period.

The Idumeans had been incorporated into the Jewish polity and had adopted Judaism. By Herod's lifetime, Idumean families could participate in Jewish political and religious life.

Likewise, it would be misleading to treat **“Hasmonean Jew”** as an ethnic category equivalent to “Jew,” because *Hasmonean* primarily refers to a **dynasty and political tradition**.

A more historically precise distinction is:

Idumean = ancestral/ethnic-geographical origin.

Judean/Jewish = broader religious, cultural, and political identity.

Hasmonean = a particular Jewish ruling dynasty and its political lineage.

9. The significance for Herod's reign

This background helps explain the extraordinary complexity of Herod's position.

Herod was:

Idumean by ancestral origin → Judaized through his family's history → politically connected to Judea → supported by Rome → married into the Hasmonean dynasty → ultimately destroyed much of that dynasty.

Therefore, Herod's story cannot accurately be reduced to either “**a foreign ruler over the Jews**” or “**an ordinary Judean Jew**.”

He was a **Judaized Idumean king of Judea whose legitimacy was contested because he stood outside the traditional Hasmonean royal lineage**, even while he actively patronized Jewish religion and the Jerusalem Temple.

This distinction is especially useful when discussing **Herod's cruelty toward the Hasmoneans and other Jewish opponents**: it was primarily a question of **dynastic power, legitimacy, and political survival**, rather than a simple war between Idumeans and Jews.

The Twelve Tribes of Israel, the Idumeans, and the Hasmoneans: A Historical Distinction

A clear distinction must be made between the **Twelve Tribes of Israel**, the **Idumeans**, and the **Hasmoneans**. Although all three became relevant to the history of ancient Judea, they were not equivalent groups and should not be described as three Jewish tribes.

1. The Twelve Tribes of Israel

According to the Hebrew Bible, the people of Israel descended from **Jacob**, whose name was changed to **Israel**. Jacob had twelve sons, traditionally regarded as the ancestors of the twelve tribes of Israel.

The traditional tribal names are:

1. Reuben
2. Simeon
3. Levi
4. Judah
5. Dan
6. Naphtali
7. Gad
8. Asher
9. Issachar
10. Zebulun
11. Joseph
12. Benjamin

However, the biblical lists sometimes vary because the tribe of **Levi** was set apart for priestly service, while Joseph's descendants were represented by **Ephraim and Manasseh**.

The Twelve Tribes therefore refer to the ancient **Israelite tribal structure**, not to every population that later became Jewish.

2. The Idumeans

The **Idumeans**, or Edomites, were a distinct people associated with **Edom**, traditionally descended from **Esau**, the brother of Jacob.

The biblical genealogy therefore distinguishes them from the Israelites:

Isaac → Jacob/Israel → Israelites

and

Isaac → Esau/Edom → Edomites

Consequently, the Idumeans were **not one of the Twelve Tribes of Israel**.

During the Hellenistic period, however, Idumea came under the control of the Hasmonean Jewish state. According to the Jewish historian Josephus, **John Hyrcanus I conquered the Idumeans and required them to adopt Jewish practices, including circumcision, as a condition of incorporation into the Jewish polity**.

Over subsequent generations, Idumeans became integrated into Jewish society. Thus, by the time of **Herod the Great**, an Idumean family could be Jewish in religious and political identity while retaining Idumean ancestry.

3. The Hasmoneans

The **Hasmoneans were not a tribe**.

The name refers to a **Jewish priestly family and ruling dynasty** that emerged from the Maccabean revolt against Seleucid rule in the second century BCE.

The movement began with **Mattathias** and his sons, most famously **Judas Maccabeus**. Their successors eventually established an independent Jewish state and ruled Judea for roughly a century.

The Hasmoneans therefore belong to the category of **dynasty**, not tribe.

Their importance was both political and religious. Hasmonean rulers controlled Judea and, at various times, also exercised the office of the Jewish high priest.

4. The fundamental difference

The simplest way to understand the distinction is:

The Twelve Tribes = ancient Israelite tribal divisions.

The Idumeans = a people of Edomite ancestry who were later incorporated into the Jewish polity and adopted Judaism.

The Hasmoneans = a Jewish priestly ruling dynasty.

Thus, neither **Idumeans** nor **Hasmoneans** should be described as two additional Jewish tribes alongside the Twelve Tribes.

5. Where Herod the Great fits

This distinction is especially important for understanding **Herod the Great**.

Herod's father, **Antipater**, came from an Idumean family. Herod therefore had **Idumean ancestral origins**, while his family had already been incorporated into the Jewish political and religious world.

Herod was not a member of the Hasmonean dynasty. Nevertheless, he married **Mariamne I**, a Hasmonean princess. This marriage helped strengthen his political legitimacy because the Hasmoneans were the established Jewish ruling dynasty that preceded him.

Herod subsequently became increasingly hostile toward the Hasmonean family. Several members of the dynasty were executed during his reign, including Mariamne I and her sons.

This makes Herod's position historically complex:

Idumean ancestry + Jewish religious/political identity + Roman political support + marriage into the Hasmonean dynasty.

6. Why the distinction matters

It is inaccurate to describe ancient Judean society as consisting simply of “twelve tribes” throughout the entire Second Temple period.

By Herod's time, the social and political situation had changed considerably. The ancient tribal system remained important in Jewish tradition and identity, but Judea had become a more complex society containing people of different ancestral backgrounds who had become part of Judaism and the Jewish polity.

Therefore, when discussing Herod, the most historically precise description is:

Herod the Great was a Jewish ruler of Judea from a Judaized Idumean family; he was not a member of the ancient Twelve Tribes as a separate tribal group and was not a Hasmonean.

The distinction between **ancestry, religious identity, and political dynasty** is essential for understanding Jewish history in the late Second Temple period.

The Hasmonean Jews: Ancestry, Tribe, and Abrahamic Lineage

The **Hasmoneans** were a Jewish priestly family that established the Hasmonean dynasty in Judea after the Maccabean revolt. They were **not a separate tribe of Israel**. Rather, they belonged to the Jewish priestly tradition and are associated with the **tribe of Levi**.

1. Their connection to Abraham

According to the biblical genealogical tradition, the ancestry of the Israelites runs through **Isaac and Jacob (Israel)**.

The broad lineage is:

Abraham → Isaac → Jacob (Israel) → Levi → priestly families

Jacob had twelve sons, who became the ancestors of the traditional Twelve Tribes of Israel. **Levi** was one of those twelve sons.

The Hasmoneans emerged from a Jewish priestly family associated with this **Levitical/Aaronic tradition**.

Thus, their Abrahamic lineage is understood as:

Abraham → Isaac → Jacob/Israel → Levi → priestly lineage → Hasmoneans

They therefore belong to the **Isaac–Israelite line**, not the Ishmaelite line.

2. Abraham's sons and the Hasmoneans

Abraham is traditionally described as having several sons, but two are particularly important for understanding the biblical family line:

- **Ishmael**, son of Abraham and Hagar
- **Isaac**, son of Abraham and Sarah

The people of Israel trace their covenantal ancestry through **Isaac** → **Jacob/Israel**.

Since the Hasmoneans were a Jewish priestly family within the Israelite/Judean tradition, their ancestral tradition belongs to the **Isaac** → **Jacob/Israel** line.

They were therefore not descendants of Ishmael in the traditional biblical genealogy.

3. From Jacob to Levi

Jacob, also called **Israel**, had twelve sons. One of them was **Levi**.

The traditional tribal sequence is:

Abraham

↓

Isaac

↓

Jacob (Israel)

↓

Levi

↓

Levitical priestly families

The tribe of Levi was set apart for religious service in ancient Israel.

Within the tribe of Levi, the descendants of **Aaron**, the brother of Moses, held the special priestly office.

Therefore, the term **Levite** and the term **priest (Kohen)** are related but not identical:

- A **Levite** belongs to the tribe of Levi.
- A **Kohen** is a priest traditionally descended from Aaron, who was himself a Levite.

4. The Hasmoneans and the priesthood

The Hasmonean family emerged during the second century BCE.

Mattathias, the father of the Maccabean leaders, was a Jewish priest from **Modi'in**. His sons, particularly **Judas Maccabeus**, led the revolt against Seleucid rule.

The Hasmoneans eventually established an independent Jewish state and became its ruling dynasty.

They exercised both **political and religious authority**, including control of the high priesthood.

Consequently, the Hasmoneans are best understood as a **Jewish priestly ruling dynasty**, rather than as a separate Israelite tribe.

5. Hasmonean does not mean a new tribe

The word **Hasmonean** refers to the family/dynasty.

It does not mean:

“the thirteenth tribe of Israel.”

The traditional Twelve Tribes existed independently of the later Hasmonean dynasty.

Therefore:

Tribe = Levi

Priestly lineage = Aaronic tradition

Dynasty = Hasmonean

These terms describe different aspects of identity.

6. Hasmoneans and Herod

This distinction becomes especially important when comparing the Hasmoneans with **Herod the Great**.

The Hasmoneans were a Jewish priestly dynasty that had ruled Judea before Herod.

Herod, by contrast, came from an **Idumean family that had been incorporated into the Jewish polity and had adopted Judaism**.

Herod was therefore not a Hasmonean.

He married **Mariamne I**, a Hasmonean princess, which connected him to the old Jewish royal dynasty. Nevertheless, Herod eventually ordered the execution of Mariamne and other members of the Hasmonean family.

This created a striking political contrast:

Hasmoneans: Jewish priestly dynasty with Israelite/Levitical tradition.

Herod: Judaized Idumean royal family supported by Rome.

7. Important historical qualification

The broad identification of the Hasmoneans as a **priestly/Levitical family** is well established in the historical tradition. However, a complete, independently documented genealogical chain from the historical Hasmoneans back through every generation to **Levi or Aaron** cannot be reconstructed with certainty.

Therefore, a careful historical statement is:

The Hasmoneans were a Jewish priestly family traditionally belonging to the Levitical/Aaronic priestly tradition. They emerged as the ruling dynasty of Judea during the Maccabean period and ultimately traced their Jewish identity through the Israelite line of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob.

Simplified lineage

Abraham
↓
Isaac
↓
Jacob / Israel
↓
Levi
↓
Priestly/Levitical tradition
↓
Hasmonean priestly family
↓
Mattathias
↓
Judas Maccabeus and the Hasmonean rulers

Thus, the Hasmoneans should be understood as **Jewish priests and rulers arising from the Israelite/Judean tradition, not as a separate tribe alongside the Twelve Tribes.**